

Experts' opinions

Seasoned diplomats offer their viewpoints on how to put pressure on Pakistan

M.K. RASGOTRA



Former Foreign Secretary

■ We are talking too much in different voices from South Block each contradicting the other and the impression that is gaining ground is that it is simply verbal anger. We must make it clear to the international community that if they fail to discipline Pakistan we will do it.

KANWAL SIBAL



Former Foreign Secretary

■ We must ask the US to force Pakistan act against terrorism within a time frame. At the Friends of Pakistan meeting later this month we should ensure that economic assistance becomes conditional. We should also consider withdrawal of High Commissioners.

G. PARTHASARTHY



Former envoy to Pakistan

■ We need to build covert capabilities in Pakistan and mount psychological war. We should not shy away from political destabilisation and inflicting economic damage to Pakistan. The time has come for us to say that Pakistan's border with Afghanistan is disputed.

LALIT MANSINGH



Former Foreign Secretary

■ Bilateral pressure from India makes Pakistan more hostile. The country is in a financial mess. President Zardari has asked for a huge bailout. We should ask the international community to tie this aid to Pakistan dismantling the terror infrastructure.

Action plan

diplomatic relations and banned all civilian flights coming in from Pakistan. It also cut off economic and cultural ties. But that would soon prove counterproductive and, after a year or so, diplomatic relations were restored.

After the Mumbai attacks India is now in the unenviable position of being reduced to a binary option: launch a limited war that could escalate into a nuclear conflict and bring international intervention or watch with increasing frustration as Pakistan denies every charge being made against it and does nothing against terrorism.

There are lessons that India should learn from the 1971 conflict that was a result of careful strategy and planning. What the current situation calls for is a similar massive effort with a clear end goal in sight. If the 1971 objective was to dismember Pakistan then the 2009 game plan should be to neu-

MOUNT a sustained diplomatic campaign to build international pressure, especially from the US, by providing evidence of Pakistan's complicity. The message must go out: if they fail to bring Pakistan around, India is ready for war.

EXPLOIT the divisions within Pakistan and expose its weaknesses in Baluchistan, the FATA and PoK. Drive a wedge between the army and the jihadis. Also win over the moderate democratic forces.

EXPLORE a range of diplomatic and economic sanctions, including withdrawing most favoured nation status, scrapping the joint terror mechanism and keeping on hold sports and cultural links.

SET a timeline for Pakistan to dismantle terror infrastructure. Use legal instruments such as the SAARC convention on terrorism to extradite perpetrators of Mumbai 26/11.

tralise Pakistan so that it can no longer pose a threat to India.

The buzzword is 'smart' strategy that calls for India to work on multiple pressure points to force Pakistan into taking action to dismantle its extensive terror network. India must continue to build international pressure especially from the US by providing evidence of Pakistan's complicity. It should also mount pressure in the UN for a comprehensive convention on terrorism that could entail the international community taking action against Pakistan. It can also begin to look at a range of diplomatic and economic sanctions to further isolate Pakistan. That could include suspending its most favoured nation status for trade. It should also mount pressure on Pakistan to hand over the perpetrators of the Mumbai attacks. Pakistan must know that if there is another terrorist strike, it would mean war.